THE ARTISTS



KAPILA VENU, 44
Koodiyattam performer
Irinjalakuda, Kerala

The Dance of Continuity

There is nothing simple about Koodiyattam, the colourful 2,000-year-old temple art form that is a mix of Sanskrit drama and Kerala folk traditions. The drama, which mostly plays out seated, involves intense use of the eyes (*netra abhinaya*) and hands (*hasta abhinaya*), and is many a time an elaborate production. Enacted by Nangiars (women performers) and Chakyars (male actors), the performances unfold over multiple nights at the temple *koothambalam* (internal stage), sometimes even extending for over a month.

This was the tradition Kapila Venu was born into. The daughter of Mohiniyattam guru, Nirmala Panicker, and renowned Koodiyattam artiste, G. Venu, she spent her childhood in two places: Lawrence School, Lovedale, where her mother was teaching, and at 'Natanakairali', the centre for traditional performing arts Venu founded in 1975 in Irinjalakuda, Thrissur. Kapila's initiation into Koodiyattam began at age 7, and she had a 10-year apprenticeship under the legendary Ammannur Madhava Chakyar in the gurukulam tradition. But she says it was father Venu's advice and supervision that turned her into the performer she is today. Along the way, she also trained in Mohiniyattam, Kerala's own martial arts form Kalaripayattu, and Nangiarkoothu, a female, solo version of Koodiyattam.

In a three-decade-long career, Kapila has trained and collaborated with many internationally acclaimed dancer-artistes, including Min Tanaka and Akram Khan. She has also performed across Europe and the US, starting with a full-length Koodiyattam performance in Sweden when she was just 17. Kapila's feminist politics is integrated into her art, even while performing classical heroines such as Gandhari, Vasantasena or Kannagi. Winner of several awards, including the Kumar Gandharva Samman and the Kerala Sangeetha Nataka Akademi Award, she was also the subject of a National Award-winning, eponymously titled documentary, directed by Sanju Surendran. ■

—Jeemon Jacob

HER TAKE

I do not believe in separating art from the artist. I believe artists have a responsibility to strive to be humane, ethical and accountable in the way they live and work

WHAT MAKES HER A SHERO

An exponent of Koodiyattam, one of Kerala's oldest living theatre traditions, Kapila won global acclaim for her work in Akram Khan's dance-theatre piece, *Gigenis*, in 2025